attract foreign investment and provide jobs, the PM launched a production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme in 14 sectors. The foreign direct investment policy was further liberalised—most sectors were opened to 100 per cent FDI under the automatic route. Says Kant, the CEO of NITI Aayog then, "The prime minister is very futuristic in his approach and focused on technology. He is a very hard taskmaster. He always adds value to our presentations. He wants India to be the best in the world in delivery, never second-class." Before the pandemic, Modi had pared the corporate tax base for existing companies from 30 per cent to 22 per cent, a move that helped the economy reboot post-Covid.

Other economic reforms included opening key sectors like space, atomic energy and defence to more private sector participation and introducing far-reaching reforms to free agriculture of stifling government controls. Modi presented them as part of an Aatmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan to make India self-reliant, in May 2020, in the thick of the first phase of Covid, setting aside Rs 27.1 lakh crore for it for five years. Says Mishra, "The reforms initiated during Covid as well as the steep increase in capital investment by the government saw India register a GDP growth of 7.2 per cent in 2022-23, making it the fastest-growing major economy in the world, ahead of even China."

The agriculture sector, though, showed itself closed to the idea of reform. Major protests broke out among farmers in the key foodgrain-producing states of Punjab and Haryana, forcing the Modi government to withdraw its contentious farm laws and apologise for the inconvenience caused. The PM, his aides say, has imbibed valuable lessons from these setbacks and is much more thorough about the implications and downsides of major decisions before going ahead with them. So, when it came to education, the National Education Policy or NEP, 2020, was announced after much debate, and is expected to bring about far-reaching changes in the curriculum. College admissions, too, are set for radical change with the introduction of the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) last year to provide students with a more level playing field. Even GST was modified to remove irritants, which saw both compliance and collection shoot up considerably and exceed targets.

On foreign policy, Modi has been both bold and brave. He has fashioned a multi-aligned foreign policy that has enabled India to do business with Russia after its invasion of Ukraine even as it collaborates with the US to deal with Chinese belligerence. On China's border intrusion, Modi firmly pushed for the restoration of status quo by making military manoeuvres to degrade the Chinese offensive. He also engaged allies, including the US, Japan and Australia, in the mission to contain China by energising the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue or Quad.

India's exports, too, are looking good after the Modi government worked to remove bottlenecks. Merchandise exports crossed the $400 billion mark in FY22, and service exports are seeing a boom too. Two major trade agreements have been signed with Australia and the UAE. The government seems to be following a give-and-take approach. Import duties for Australian wines, among other things, have dropped considerably.

Meanwhile, Modi is leveraging the presidency of the G20 and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation this year to enhance India's international stature. Internally, his government shut the door firmly on China and Pakistan's claim that Kashmir was disputed territory by abrogating Article 370 in an audacious move, bifurcating the state into the Union territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh.



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THE LAST MILE

In the final months of his second term, says Mishra, the prime minister is focusing on implementation and improving the speed of delivery. He and Mishra are personally monitoring all the major programmes of the government, identifying bottlenecks and pushing hard for outcomes. Modi has adopted the unusual approach of sending out joint secretaries from various ministries to visit states and give on-the-ground feedback and fine-tune programmes accordingly.

However, there are several areas where progress has been slow. Despite announcing major privatisation and disinvestment plans, barring Air India and to some extent, LIC, the government missed 30 per cent of its disinvestment target last year and is still to retreat from a large number of areas. In job-creating sectors such as textiles, tourism and skill development, there have been inexplicable lags in performance. One of the major engines of growth, exports, is showing signs of stagnation; FDI, too, worryingly contracted by as much as 22 per cent or a fifth in 2022-23. The Opposition criticises Modi for being arrogant and